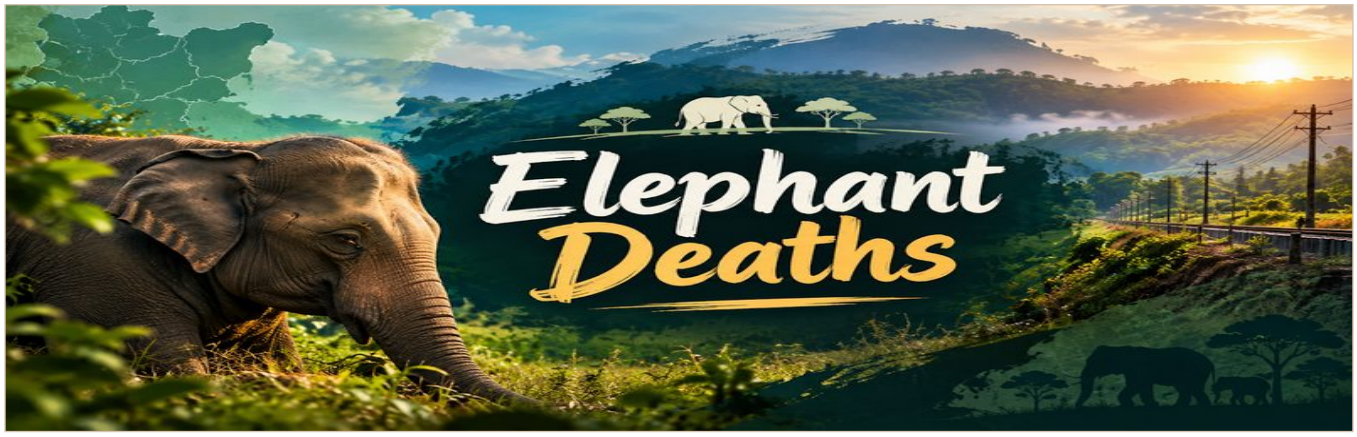


Akella Raghavendra Sir
Founder & Chief Mentor

[GS PAPER III – ENVIRONMENT AND ECOLOGY] | **Publication Date: 28/09/2026**

Elephant Deaths



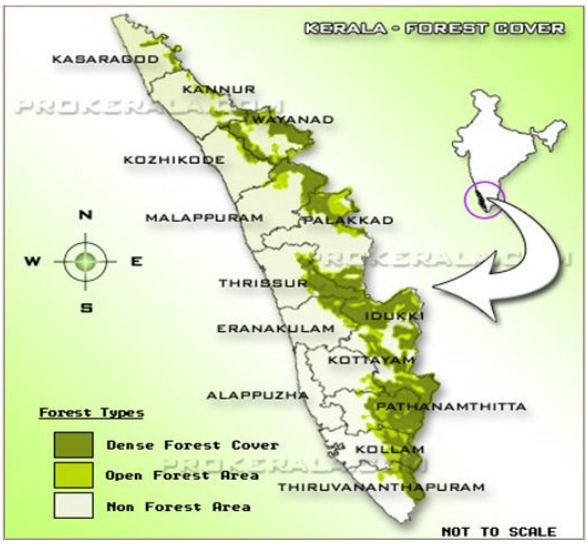
Human–elephant conflict in Kerala is intensifying due to habitat intrusion, crop raiding and human-induced threats such as electrocution and explosives. The article examines elephant mortality hotspots and highlights the need for effective wildlife conservation and conflict mitigation measures.

Elephant Deaths

Syllabus areas:

GS Paper III – Environment and Ecology

Human-induced elephant deaths are back in focus in Kerala after the death of a makhna (tuskless male) elephant reportedly after chewing on fruit stuffed with explosives, in the Malayattoor forests in Ernakulam district, Kerala.



This is the continuing elephant killings in Munnar – Pambikulam - Malayattor forest sector, one of the major elephant mortality hotspots in Kerala.

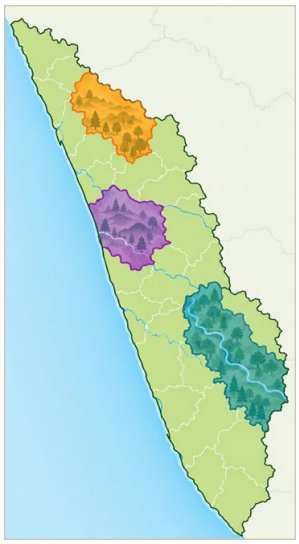


Crop raiding and habitat intrusion by elephants and retaliation by humans have contributed to elephant deaths.

Electrocution is the leading unnatural cause of death, with incident rates tripling over six years.

Explosives and poaching persist as threats, with juveniles 744 wild elephants died between April 2019 and March 2025, while human-induced causes accounted for 77 deaths. Munnar and Ranni areas accounted for the highest incidence of electrocution.

The primary elephant mortality zones in the State also included the wayanad landscape, Nilambur region and the Periyar – Ranni–Konni landscape.



- Orange: Wayanad landscape (Northern Kerala)
- Purple: Nilambur region (North-central Kerala)
- Blue/Teal: Periyar–Ranni–Konni landscape (Central and southeastern Kerala)

The death of a pregnant wild elephant in the Silent Valley forest in 2020, after feeding on fruit stuffed with firecrackers. The animal was unable to eat after feeding on the fruit and suffering injuries to its mouth, the animal had stayed in a river in an apparent effort to ease pain.